

A REVIVAL? Sambhajiraje at the May 27 Swarajya convention in Pune

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WHO IS SAMBHAJIRAJE?

Sambhajiraje is the eldest son of Chhatrapati Shahu II of Kolhapur. He came into public life through the hardline Maratha organisations Maratha Seva Sangh and the Sambhaji Brigade. In 2007, he started annual celebrations of the coronation ceremony of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj at Raigad, which helped build his public profile. Two years later, though, he lost from the Kolhapur Lok Sabha seat, contesting as an NCP nominee. Later, Sambhajiraje emerged as one of the faces of the Maratha reservation protests, especially after 2011, and toured the state as part of the 'Shiv-Shahu yatra'. He is currently also the chairperson of the Raigad Development Authority, which oversees the conservation of Shivaji's historic fort of the same name.

MAHARASHTRA

POLITICS WITH A HINT OF ROYALTY

SAMBHAJIRAJE WILL HAVE TO CREATE ROOM IN MAHARASHTRA'S CROWDED POLITICAL FIELD

and over a dozen others are already part of mainstream parties.

Sambhajiraje's presence could affect the fortunes of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and, by extension, the opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) alliance as he may walk away with a section of the Maratha vote in regions like Marathwada and Nashik. As one of the faces of the protests seeking quotas for the dominant Maratha community, the former Rajya Sabha MP (nominated) has a base among the Maratha youth in Marathwada, an area infamous for agrarian distress. MVA leaders, however, say it's the ruling BJP that will take a dent as some of their young pro-Hindutva voters would be swayed by the ex-royal's connection to Shivaji.

"As of now, we are planning to go it alone... but we are not averse to an alliance with like-minded parties," Sambhajiraje told INDIA TODAY. "We have a good space (available for us), (there is a) vacuum," he said when asked about the fortunes of the new party in a state where the political arena is crowded with the BJP and its ally, the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, along with the MVA which has the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), NCP and the Congress. Parties like the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS), Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi (VBA), the Left, smaller sub-regional outfits, and new entrant Bharat Rashtra Samiti (BRS), already make up a populous fringe.

An office-bearer of Swarajya said they would contest the Lok Sabha election, but the assembly poll was the main focus. The organisation currently has 89 gram panchayat members and 22 sarpanches in Nashik, Kolhapur, Aurangabad and Beed districts. "There is anger against established politicians and their politics. This sentiment saw people voting for Raj Thackeray's MNS in 2009 and Prakash Ambedkar's VBA in 2019. Sambhajiraje is a new face and has a social justice background (his great-grandfather 'Rajarshi' Shahu was the first to launch quotas for weaker sections in Kolhapur in 1902), which may help in taking over the anti-establishment space," explains a senior leader of the Maratha community. He claims that Swarajya could alter the results in 25-30 assembly seats, adding that the weakening hold of Sharad Pawar over the NCP would also work to Sambhajiraje's advantage. "But his future lies in striking an alliance with established players...even the BJP needs local satraps," he points out.

Incidentally, it was Sambhajiraje's